

Data Handling: Import, Cleaning and Visualisation

Exercise/Workshop 2: Functions, iterations and data structures

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All course material: https://github.com/ASallin/BEcon_3230_Datahandling_ImportCleaningandVisualization	

Before we start

Write your code in an R script saved in `2026_Data_Handling/exercises/code`, for example `exercise_02.R`. Start from the code shown in the lecture slides whenever you can. Type the code rather than copying it, and read every error message. If something does not work, raise your hand.

Exercise	What we do
1	Write a sum function
2	Make the function robust
3	Apply the function to a list: <code>lapply()</code> , <code>loop</code> , <code>map()</code>
4	Slow and fast sloths: a <code>while</code> loop
5	Data structures: vectors, factors, lists, matrices, arrays, data frames
Training	Standard deviation, standard error, t-test, comparing data frames, tibbles and data.tables

Exercise 1: write a sum function

In the lecture you saw the `for` loop: `for (i in 1:n) { ... }` repeats the body once for every value of `i`.

1. Use a `for` loop and the empty function below to write a function that takes a numeric vector as input and returns the sum of its elements. Start with a total of zero and add one element per iteration.

```
my_sum <- function(x) {  
    
}
```

2. Define the vector `numbers <- c(1, 2, 3)`. Compare your function with R's built-in `sum()`: do `my_sum(numbers)` and `sum(numbers)` give the same result?

Exercise 2: robustness and warnings

1. Call your function with the following vector as input. What happens?

```
numbers2 <- c("1", "2", "3")
```

2. Why do you get an error? Compare `numbers` from Exercise 1 with `numbers2`. The functions `str()` and `class()` help.
3. Extend `my_sum()` with a control statement that checks whether the input is numeric (hint: `is.numeric(x)`). If the input is wrong, the function should issue a warning instead of stopping with an error. Use this message:

```
warning("Wrong input! This function only accepts numeric or integer values!")
```

What should the function return in that case? Think about why returning 0 would be a bad idea.

4. Test the improved function with `numbers` and `numbers2`.

Exercise 3: apply the function to a list

You can apply a function to every element of a list in several ways. Here you do the same task three times, with a loop, with `lapply()` and with `map()`.

1. Create a list of numeric vectors:

```
list_of_numbers <- list(  
  c(1, 2, 3),  
  c(4, 5, 6),  
  c(7, 8, 9, 10)  
)
```

Access the first element of the list with `list_of_numbers[[1]]`. Note the double square brackets.

2. Use a `for` loop to apply `my_sum()` to each vector. Create an empty list `sums_loop` first, then fill it inside the loop. Print the result.
3. Do the same with `lapply()`. Store the result in `sums_lapply` and print it.
4. Do the same with `map()` from the `purrr` package. Load the package first. Store the result in `sums_map` and print it.
5. All three give the same result. When would you use which?

Exercise 4: slow and fast sloths

Loops can simulate a process over time. Write a program that calculates the populations of two kinds of sloths.

At the beginning of year 1 there are **1000 slow sloths** and **1 fast sloth**. The fast sloth is a new mutation that can use roller blades, which helps it escape from predators. Each year, every sloth has one offspring. There are no further mutations: slow sloths beget slow sloths and fast sloths beget fast sloths. Each year, 40% of all slow sloths die, but only 30% of the fast sloths.

So at the beginning of year 1 there are 1000 slow sloths. Another 1000 are born. Then 40% of these 2000 die, which leaves 1200 at the beginning of year 2. In the same year we start with 1 fast sloth, 1 more is born, and 30% of these 2 die, which leaves 1.4.

Beginning of year	Slow sloths	Fast sloths
1	1000	1
2	1200	1.4
3	1440	1.96

1. Write a **while** loop that updates both populations year by year for as long as the slow sloths are at least as numerous as the fast ones. Keep a counter for the year.
2. **In which year do the fast sloths outnumber the slow sloths for the first time?** Print the answer with `cat()`.
3. Why is a **while** loop the right tool here, and not a **for** loop?

Exercise 5: data structures

Vectors, factors and lists

1. Create a vector `student_ages` with the ages of 5 students: 18, 21, 20, 22, 19. Print its length and its type with `length()` and `typeof()`.
2. Create a factor `student_grades` with the grades of the same 5 students: "A", "B", "A", "C", "B". Print its levels. Why would you store grades as a factor rather than as text?
3. Create a vector `student_names` with 5 names. Then create a list `student_info` that combines `student_names`, `student_ages` and `student_grades`. Access its elements by position (`[[1]]`) and by name (`$names`).
4. What is the difference between a vector and a factor? Why do you use a list, and not a vector, to store data of different types together?

Matrices and arrays

1. Create a matrix `scores_matrix` with the scores of 3 students in 3 subjects. Give it row and column names with `rownames()` and `colnames()`. Print the matrix and the score of one student in one subject.
2. Create a 3-dimensional array `student_array` with the same students and subjects, but for two semesters with different scores. Access the scores of "Student 3" in the first subject across both semesters.
3. What is the difference between a matrix and an array? When would you use an array?

Data frames and tibbles

1. Create a data frame `students_df` that combines `student_names`, `student_ages`, `student_grades` and a new vector `attendance` with the class attendance in percent: 85, 92, 78, 88, 90. Access the `attendance` column, then the row of the third student.
2. Why is a data frame better suited to this kind of data than a matrix? And what is the difference between a data frame and a list?
3. Convert `students_df` to a tibble with `as_tibble()` from the `tibble` package. Call it `students_tibble`. Print both and compare the output.

Additional exercises for training

These go beyond what we cover in the session. They are good practice for the exam.

Exercise 6: standard deviation

1. In the lecture you implemented a function that computes the mean. Now write a function `my_sd()` that computes the standard deviation,

$$SD = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N-1} \sum_{i=1}^N (x_i - \bar{x})^2}.$$

Most R operators work element by element on a whole vector, so you do not need a loop.

2. Test it against R's `sd()`.

Exercise 7: standard error

Using `my_sd()`, write a function `my_se()` that computes the standard error of the sample mean,

$$SE_{\bar{x}} = \frac{SD}{\sqrt{n}}.$$

Exercises 6 and 7 show how to approach a bigger problem by breaking it into smaller ones: computing SD is one part of computing $SE_{\bar{x}}$, and you solved it separately.

Exercise 8: t-test

Using `my_se()`, write a function `my_t_test(x, mu_0)` for the one-sample [t-test](#),

$$t = \frac{\bar{x} - \mu_0}{SE_{\bar{x}}}.$$

Compare its output with `t.test(x, mu = mu_0)$statistic`.

Exercise 9: data frames, tibbles and data.tables

1. Convert `students_df` to a `data.table` with `as.data.table()` from the `data.table` package. Call it `students_dt`. Select the column `ages`, then filter the rows where the grade is “A”.
2. Do the following tasks three times, once with the data frame, once with the tibble (using `dplyr`) and once with the `data.table`, and compare the syntax:
 - keep the students with attendance above 85
 - compute the mean age of the students with grade “A” or “B”
 - add a column `grade_numeric` with 4 for “A”, 3 for “B” and 2 for “C”